Joseph: Meant for Good

Genesis 37–50

The big idea: Joseph's brothers sold him as a slave, and for thirteen years he was a slave and then a prisoner. Then God raised him to rule Egypt and save the very brothers who betrayed him. They meant evil; God meant it for good.

Before you meet: Read

Genesis 37:12–36 | Genesis 45:1–15 | Genesis 50:15–21

Open (5 minutes)

Has anyone ever wronged you in a way that God later used for good? How did you see it?

Observe (fill in from the passage)

They lifted Joseph out of the pit and sold him to the Ishmaelites for twenty shekels of _____. *(Genesis 37:28)*

Judah begged, "Please let your servant remain _____ of the boy as a servant to my lord." *(Genesis 44:33)*

"As for you, you meant _____ against me, but God meant it for _____." *(Genesis 50:20)*

Discuss

1. Judah went from selling his brother to offering himself in his brother's place. What changed him? Where have you seen God change someone like that? *Genesis 37:26–27; 38:26; 44:33*

2. Joseph asked, "Am I in the place of God?" How does trusting God as judge free us to forgive someone who meant us harm? *Genesis 50:19–21*

3. Joseph was rejected by his brothers, sold for silver, and raised to save them. Which parallel with Jesus stands out most to you? *Genesis 45:4–5; Acts 2:23–24*

4. Joseph spent at least two years forgotten in prison. Where do you need to remember that God is with you while you wait? *Genesis 39:21; 40:23; 41:1*

Memory verse

> *"As for you, you meant evil against me, but God meant it for good."*
>
> **Genesis 50:20**

Pray

Thank God that his promise never depended on the goodness of Abraham's family, or of yours. Ask him to carry you through what others meant for evil, and to give you a heart that forgives because Jesus has forgiven you.

LEADER NOTES · WEEK 14

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Session plan (about 45 minutes)

5 min	Welcome, opening prayer, and the Open question.
10 min	Read Genesis 45:1–15 and 50:15–21 aloud together.
5 min	Observe: work through the fill-ins together. Use the answer key below.
20 min	Discuss: choose three of the questions.
5 min	Pray together. Introduce the memory verse and next week's reading (Exodus 1–3).

Main points to land

1. "The LORD was with Joseph" in Potiphar's house and in prison, long before anything turned out well (Gen. 39:2, 21).
2. God's providence rules even over sin. The brothers meant evil and were guilty for it; God meant it for good (Gen. 50:20). Sin comes only from the creature, never from God (WCF 5.4).
3. Joseph and Judah point to Jesus: the rejected brother who saves, and the substitute from Judah, the Lion who conquers as the Lamb (Gen. 44:33; Acts 2:23; Rev. 5:5–6).

Core doctrine to teach

The Providence of God CORE DOCTRINE 7 OF 26

God not only made the world; he holds it together and governs everything in it, from kings and nations to sparrows and hairs on our heads. He works even through human sin and suffering for his good purposes, without ever doing evil himself. *Genesis 50:20; Proverbs 16:9; Matthew 10:29–31; Romans 8:28*

Answer key (Observe)

1. silver
2. instead
3. evil; good

Questions people will ask

If God planned it, were the brothers really guilty?

Yes. Joseph says plainly, "you meant evil against me." The same is true at the cross: Jesus was delivered up by God's definite plan, and those who killed him were lawless men (Acts 2:23). Scripture holds both together without explaining every detail, and so does the Confession (WCF 5.4).

Closing prayer

Father, thank you that your promise rests on your grace and not on our families or our goodness. Thank you for choosing sinners, for wrestling us into honesty, and for ruling even the evil done against us for good. Thank you for Jesus, the Brother who was betrayed and who saves. Make us people who forgive as we have been forgiven. Amen.